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Request for Applications (RFA)

Workforce Readiness Training for Career and
Technical Education Students II

32026-00162

Application Submission Deadline

April 10, 2026

Time: 10:00 a.m. Central Time

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1. Executive Summary, Definitions, and Standards

1.1. Executive Summary

The Texas Workforce Commission (TWC) is seeking Applications for Workforce Readiness Training for Career and Technical Education Students II. Funds will be made available to Nonprofit Organizations to develop, implement, and support Workforce Readiness Training in partnership with local employers, Local Education Agencies (LEAs), and other community partners.

1.2. Definitions and Acronyms

The following definitions and acronyms are applicable to this RFA.

Unless a different definition is specified, or the context clearly indicates otherwise, the definitions and acronyms given to a term below apply whenever the term appears in this RFA. All other terms have their ordinary and common meaning.

Allocable. A cost is Allocable to a particular Grant Award if the cost is assignable to the award in accordance with relative benefits received. This standard is met if the cost satisfies any of the following criteria: (1) is incurred specifically for the Grant Award; (2) benefits both the Grant Award and other work of the Grantee and can be distributed in proportions that may be approximated using reasonable methods; or (3) is necessary to the overall operation of the Grantee and is assignable in part to the Grant Award in accordance with the cost principles that apply under the Grant Award.

Amendment (to RFA). A written clarification or revision as issued and posted by TWC.

Applicant. Any legal entity that submits an Application in response to this RFA. The term includes the individual submitting the Application who is authorized to sign the Application on behalf of the Applicant. Refer to Section 3, Applicant Eligibility Requirements of this Solicitation for further guidance.

Application. All documents the Applicant submits in response to this RFA, including all required forms. Refer to Submission Checklist of Form A, Core Application, for additional guidance.

Budget. The financial plan for carrying out the project, as requested in the Form B, Budget Workbook and formalized in the Grant Award, including required or committed Cost Sharing, if any, such as Match or Leverage. The TWC-approved Budget in the Grant Award may differ from an Applicant's requested Budget, as submitted in the Form B, Budget Workbook, because of unallowable costs that TWC removes before executing the Grant Award, Grant Award Amendments executed during the Grant Period, if authorized, or for other reasons. Also refer to Form B, Budget Workbook, Grant Award, and Grant Period.

Budget Period. In a Grant Award, the time interval from the start date of a funded portion of an award to the end date of that funded portion during which Grantees are authorized to incur financial obligations of the funds awarded. Depending on the RFA, the Grant Period for a Grant Award may have more than one Budget Period, such as if the RFA specifies that TWC will fund a Grant Award in increments, TWC exercises a Grant Award renewal option, if available, or for other reasons.

Career and Technical Education (CTE) Students. For the purposes of this RFA, high school students enrolled in programs that teach career-specific

knowledge and skills as detailed in the CTE Texas Essential Knowledge and Skills.

Certificate. A document that may be awarded by either an educational institution or independent education and training provider. Educational and training programs teach students skills related to specific occupations, whereas Certificate programs are generally created, taught, and assessed directly by the program provider. Students are awarded Certificates after successfully completing instruction and demonstrating proficiency through provider-administered exams. Obtaining a Certificate generally signifies the end of the instructional program.

Credential. The all-encompassing umbrella term used to describe any type of traditional or non-traditional award within the context of education, training, workforce, and employment development. Credentials are awarded by institutions that have relevant authority to issue such Credentials, after individuals demonstrate proficiency or competency in a specific program, occupation, or field. Credentials may be earned from various sources, including, but not limited to, educational institutions, industry associations, and government agencies.

Computing Device. Machines used acquire, store, analyze, process, and publish data and other information electronically, including accessories (or “peripherals”) for printing, transmitting, and receiving, or storing electronic information. Examples include, but are not limited to, desktops, laptops, all-in-ones, tablets, and 2-in-1s. An RFA may limit or prohibit the use of grant funds to acquire Computing Devices. Refer to Attachment 3, Budget Requirements and Instructions for any cost limitations or prohibitions that apply to the acquisition of Computing Devices under this RFA.

Cost Sharing. The portion of project costs not paid by TWC grant funds or contributions (unless authorized by the statute). The term includes, but is not limited to Match and amounts that TWC or its fund sources describe as Leverage. Refer to Attachment 3, Budget Requirements and Instructions for any Cost Sharing requirements that apply under this RFA.

Day(s). The term “day(s)” is defined as calendar day(s) unless otherwise specified.

Direct Cost. Costs that can be identified specifically with a particular final cost objective, such as a Grant Award, or other internally or externally funded activity, or that can be directly assigned to such activities relatively easily with a high degree of accuracy. Costs incurred for the same purpose in like circumstances must be treated consistently as either Direct Costs or Indirect Costs.

Equipment. Tangible, personal property having a useful life of more than one (1) year, and a per-unit acquisition cost of ten thousand dollars (\$10,000) or more. “Acquisition cost” means the (total) cost of the asset including the cost to ready the asset for its intended use. Acquisition cost for Equipment means, for example, the net invoice price for the Equipment, including the cost of any modifications, attachments, accessories, or auxiliary apparatus necessary to make it usable for the purpose for which it is acquired. Ancillary charges, such as taxes, duty, protective in transit insurance, freight, and installation may be included in or excluded from the Acquisition cost in accordance with the Grantee’s regular accounting practices.

An RFA may limit or prohibit the use of grant funds to acquire Equipment. Refer to Attachment 3, Budget Requirements and Instructions, for any cost limitations or prohibitions that apply to the acquisition of Equipment under this RFA.

Form A, Core Application. Part of the Application including Submission Checklist; Contact Information Form; Workforce Development Area(s); Financial Requirements; Reporting Requirements; Certifications; Evaluation Criteria; and Work Plan. Form A, Core Application is mandatory.

Form B, Budget Workbook. The Microsoft Excel document the Applicant uses to submit a proposed project Budget in response to this RFA. The Form B, Budget Workbook is mandatory and must be submitted with the Application, in the original format, for the Application to be considered responsive. Applications received without the completed Form B, Budget Workbook in Microsoft Excel will be disqualified.

Grant Award. The agreement entered by TWC and the Grantee as a result of this RFA, including the Grant Award Agreement and all attachments and Amendments.

Grant Period. The time which begins on the Grant Award effective date and ends on the Grant Award termination or expiration date, including extensions or renewals. The Grant Award will identify the Period of Performance and Budget Period.

Grantee. A successful Applicant that receives a TWC Grant Award under this RFA.

Indirect Cost. For certain institutions of higher education and certain nonprofit organizations, Indirect Costs are also referred to as Indirect Facilities &

Administration costs (also known as F&A costs). Indirect costs are costs incurred for a common or joint purpose benefitting more than one cost objective, and not readily assigned to the cost objectives specifically benefitted, without effort disproportionate to the results achieved. To facilitate equitable distribution of indirect expenses to the cost objectives served, it may be necessary to establish a number of pools of Indirect Costs. Indirect cost pools must be distributed to benefitted cost objectives on bases that will produce an equitable result in consideration of relative benefits derived. Refer to Attachment 3, Budget Requirements and Instructions in this RFA for cost limitations that impact Indirect Costs.

Industry-Based Certification (IBC). A nontraditional award that demonstrates proficiency and knowledge, through examination, in a specific occupation, skill, industry or trade. Obtaining an Industry-Based Certification is not dependent on any actual education or training program. Instead, evaluating candidates for certification relies on independent, third-party professional and industry-based groups. These national organizations develop and maintain relevant proficiency standards that are assessed and sanctioned by industry-approved examination facilities, independent of any educational institution or training program.

Institution of Higher Education (IHE). Texas Education Code (TEC) § 61.003(8)) defines as any public technical institute, public junior college, public senior college, or university, medical or dental unit, public state college, or other agency of higher education as defined in this section.

Local Education Agency (LEA). An authority responsible for managing and operating public kindergarten (K) through 12th grade (K–12) schools within a

specific area. Independent Schools Districts and Open Enrollment Charter Schools are examples of LEAs.

Nonprofit Organization. An organization exempt from federal income taxation under Internal Revenue Code § 501(c)(3), or § 509(a)(1-4). For a Nonprofit Organization to participate in WIOA-funded programs, it must be able to demonstrate:

- 1) Expertise in workforce development; and
- 2) Effectiveness in providing educational and related services to individuals.

Period of Performance. In a Grant Award, the time interval between the start and end date of the award, which may include one or more Budget Periods. Basically, the time during which a Grantee may perform approved grant-funded activities under a Grant Award. Refer to the definitions for Budget Period and Grant Period.

Pre-Award Costs. Costs incurred before the start date of the Grant Award.

Program Income. Gross income earned by the Grantee that is directly generated by a supported activity or earned as a result of the Grant Award during the Period of Performance. Refer to the definition for Period of Performance. For more information, refer to 2 C.F.R. § 200.307 Program Income in the Uniform Guidance and to the Program Income section in the Texas Grant Management Standards (TxGMS), as applicable. Note: If a governing federal or state program requirement supersedes the Uniform Guidance or TxGMS, as applicable, that superseding requirement prevails over the general definition in the RFA.

Request for Applications (RFA). This Solicitation; Form A, Core Application; Form B, Budget Workbook; Question and Answer Document; all other forms; attachments; and Amendments posted by TWC.

Solicitation. This document, including attachments, that describes the program or project requirements.

State. The State of Texas and its instrumentalities, including Texas Workforce Commission (TWC) and any other state agency, its officers, employees, or authorized agents.

Subrecipient. An entity that receives a subgrant from a pass-through entity to carry out part of a Grant Award. For example, if a Grantee makes a subgrant to carry out part of the Grant Award, the Grantee is a pass-through entity and the entity that receives the subgrant is a Subrecipient of the Grantee for purposes of that award. Characteristics which support the classification of an entity as a Subrecipient include when that entity: (1) determines who is eligible to receive what federal or state assistance; (2) has its performance measured in relation to whether objectives of the federal or state program were met; (3) has responsibility for programmatic decision-making; (4) is responsible for adherence to applicable federal or state program requirements specified in the Grant Award; and (5) in accordance with its agreement, used the funds to implement a Program for a public purpose specified in authorizing statute, as opposed to providing goods or services for the benefit of the pass-through entity. In determining whether an agreement between a pass-through entity and another entity casts the latter as a Subrecipient or a contractor (vendor), the substance of the relationship is more important than the form of the agreement. All of the characteristics listed above may not be present in all cases, and the pass-through entity must use judgment in classifying each

agreement as a subgrant to carry out part of the Grant Award, or a procurement contract for the purchase of goods and services.

System for Award Management (SAM.gov). An official website of the U.S. government. It is used by entities to obtain a federally-assigned Unique Entity Identifier (UEI), and for other purposes. In addition to having a UEI, TWC may require some Grantees to maintain an active account registration on SAM.gov to help facilitate TWC reporting under the Federal Funding Accountability and Transparency Act (FFATA). There is no cost to use SAM.gov. Section 8.8, Compliance for Participation in Grant Awards of this Solicitation discusses related FFATA reporting requirements. Section 13, Informational Resources of this Solicitation provides a link to SAM.gov.

The Texas Essential Knowledge and Skills (TEKS). State standards adopted by the Texas State Board of Education that outline what students in Texas public schools should know and be able to do in each subject and grade level.

Texas Grant Management Standards (TxGMS). Standards issued by the Texas Comptroller of Public Accounts, which provides administrative requirements, cost principles, and audit requirements for state awards, and supplements the UG for federal awards.

Uniform Guidance (UG). The “Uniform Administrative Requirements, Cost Principles, and Audit Requirements for Federal Awards,” issued by the federal Office of Budget and Management (OMB), and codified at Title 2, Part 200, Code of Federal Regulations (C.F.R.) (2 C.F.R. Part 200) as amended by federal agencies’ adoptions in Title 2, Subtitle B of the C.F.R.

Will. A statement containing the term “will” means the statement is a requirement of the RFA. The term “will” is interchangeable with the term “must” and has the same meaning as the term “shall”.

Workforce Readiness Training. Comprised of a set of skills and behaviors that are necessary for any job. These skills and behaviors are also referred to as soft skills and include, but are not limited to, communication, organization, teamwork, problem-solving, critical thinking, adaptability, conflict resolution, and time management.

1.3. Standards

Grant Awards made as a result of this RFA are subject to all policies, terms, and conditions set forth in or included with this RFA as well as applicable statutes, requirements, and guidelines.

2. Scope of Grant

2.1. Purpose

Texas employers have identified a lack of workforce readiness skills, especially in individuals who are new to the workforce. A lack of such skills presents a consistent challenge in the hiring and retention of employees.

The purpose of the Workforce Readiness Training for Career and Technical (CTE) Students program is to:

- 1) create new or expand existing Workforce Readiness Training programs used by Local Education Agencies (LEAs), employers, and other community partners; and

- 2) develop, implement, and support training designed to build CTE students' workforce readiness skills.

2.2. Eligible Population to be Served

The eligible population to be served under this Grant Award consists of CTE Students.

2.3. Program Requirements or Scope

An Applicant will provide information on the following Program Requirements in the Application.

a) Demonstrated Experience

Applicants will describe their experience with:

- i) developing curriculum;
- ii) implementing curriculum; and
- iii) collaborating with stakeholders.

b) Program Plan

Applicants will submit a Program Plan describing how they will:

- i) create a new or expand an existing program, including an overall description of the program;
- ii) engage with local employers to identify and address workforce readiness skills needed within local businesses or industries;
- iii) collaborate with LEA stakeholders (for example, school administrators, CTE program directors, CTE teachers) and community partners to implement a Workforce Readiness Training program;
- iv) prepare students for successful entry into occupations that meet the workforce needs of their communities;
- v) award Credential(s) to each student who successfully completes training; and
- vi) develop and implement new or implement existing curriculum that aligns with TEKS for CTE programs (that is, aligns with TEKS that addresses “professional standards and employability skills as required by business and industry”).

c) Program Administration Plan

Applicants will submit a Program Administration Plan describing the:

- i) staff positions to be funded under this grant;
- ii) staff qualifications and number of years' experience in a relevant field;
- iii) staff roles and responsibilities (including partners, if any) working on this program;
- iv) plan for forming partnerships with LEAs; and
- v) plan for recruiting and enrolling CTE Students.

d) Outcomes and Measures

i) Program Performance Measures are as follows:

- (1) Number of classes to be offered; and
- (2) Number of training faculty on staff.

ii) Program Benchmarks are as follows:

- (1) Number of students enrolled;
- (2) Number of students who complete the training program;
- (3) Number of students who show proficiency in workforce readiness skills as determined by the CTE Program;
- (4) Number and name of Credential(s), such as Certificates and Industry-Based Certifications, awarded per student upon completion of training.

2.4. Reporting Requirements

A Grantee will be required to submit monthly progress reports, quarterly performance reports, a financial closeout package and ad-hoc reports to TWC. A Grantee is also required to submit a final report in a format specified by TWC not later than thirty (30) days after the grant end date. The requirements further identified in Reporting Requirements of Form A, Core Application and incorporated into the Grant Award.

2.5. Performance Measures

TWC will look solely to Grantee for the performance of all Grantee obligations and requirements in a Grant Award resulting from this RFA. Grantee will not be relieved of its obligations for any nonperformance by its Subrecipients or subcontractors, if any.

Grantees must regularly collect and maintain data that measures the performance and effectiveness of activities under a Grant Award resulting from this RFA in the manner, and within the timeframes specified in this RFA and resulting Grant Award, or as otherwise specified by TWC.

2.6. Monitoring

Grants awarded under this RFA are subject to TWC monitoring activities throughout the duration of the Grant Period. This evaluation may include a reassessment of project activities and services to determine whether they continue to be effective throughout the Grant Period.

Items that a Grantee must maintain on site and make available for TWC include the following:

- a) a list of participants and participant files verifying eligibility, if applicable;
- b) all financial records pertaining to the Grant Award;
- c) policies and procedures pertaining to the Grant Award, if applicable;
- d) a list of entities that receive funds under any Grant Award resulting from this RFA; and
- e) documentation of monitoring and oversight activities of other grant partners and Subrecipients, if applicable.

3. Applicant Eligibility Requirements

An Eligible Applicant under this RFA is a Nonprofit Organization as defined in Section 1.2, Definitions and Acronyms, of this RFA Solicitation.

Nonprofit Organizations do not have to be Texas-based; however, they must provide a physical, Texas-based address on the Contact Information Form in the Application that is within the community or communities it proposes to serve.

For the purposes of this RFA, LEAs, IHEs, Regional Education Service Centers and Local Workforce Development Boards are not considered Eligible Applicants.

Nonprofit Organizations must provide verifiable evidence of their status by providing an Internal Revenue Service Certification (Determination Letter) or other verifiable documentation such as its registration by the Texas Secretary of State with the Application.

An Applicant may submit only one (1) Application. If more than one (1) Application is received from an Applicant, TWC will only screen and evaluate the **last** Application received from that Applicant.

4. Grant Period and Funding

4.1. Grant Period

Funding will be for approximately twenty-four (24) months from the grant start date, with the option of renewals or extensions in any combination of years or months, at TWC's discretion, provided that the total Grant Period does not exceed five (5) years. In considering such renewal, TWC will consider performance, progress toward expected outcomes, and expenditures, as well as other factors.

4.2. Statutory Authority, Funding Source, and Available Funding

Approximately eight million dollars (\$8,000,000) is available for grant(s), based on the availability of funds and as approved by TWC. This amount does not include additional funding that may be added in subsequent years to fund a renewal or extension.

The funding source(s) for Workforce Readiness Training for CTE Students II program is Workforce Innovation and Opportunity Act (WIOA) Title I Statewide Activity funds, as appropriated under funding through the Full-Year Continuing Appropriations and Extensions Act, 2025 (Public Law 119-4) as applicable, and any further TWC issuances.

The statutory authority is WIOA Title I, Public Law (Pub. L.) 113-128, 29 United States Code (U.S.C.) § 3101 et seq., as implemented in the regulations at 20

C.F.R. Parts 675 through 687, Workforce Development (WD) Letters, as applicable, and any further TWC issuances.

This RFA is financed under a federal award supporting this program. The federal award is financed one hundred percent (100%) with federal money.

4.3. Maximum Award

TWC will award grants to the high-quality Applications that demonstrate the ability to meet the program criteria as much as possible with the available funding. The maximum amount that can be requested by Applicants is two million dollars (\$2,000,000).

Successful Applications may not be funded to the full extent of Applicant's requested Budget(s).

4.4. No Guarantees in Awarding of Grants

TWC has the right to reject Applications, or to cancel or modify an RFA at any point before a Grant Award is signed. TWC reserves the right to cancel, make partial award, or decline to award a grant under this RFA at any time in its sole discretion. Submission of an Application in response to this RFA does not place any obligation on TWC to make a Grant Award.

Final approval of a Grant Award is solely at the determination of TWC. Funding beyond this grant cycle is not guaranteed. Renewals are not automatic and are based on Grantee performance, meeting or exceeding performance and expenditure benchmarks, or other factors as determined by TWC. Grantees should not expect to receive additional or continued funding under future RFA opportunities and should maintain sustainability plans.

5. Application Forms for Submission

5.1. Form A, Core Application

Applicants will use Work Plan of Form A, Core Application to describe their proposed activities, processes, and methodologies to satisfy all objectives described in Section 2, Scope of Grant of this Solicitation. Applicants should identify all proposed tasks to be performed, including all program activities, during the Grant Period. Refer to Evaluation Criteria of Form A, Core Application for additional information.

5.2. Form B, Budget Workbook

Applicants will use Form B, Budget Workbook to provide the requested Budget to support their program, in alignment with the requirements described in Attachment 3, Budget Requirements and Instructions, and the program requirements of the RFA. Applicants will utilize the Form B, Budget Workbook to identify all Budget line items and matching costs. Describe in detail how costs were determined and justified, including providing any formulas used to calculate totals. Ensure costs are aligned to the Program Administration Plan and Program Plan. Do not alter formulas in Form B, Budget Workbook. Doing so may result in disqualification of the Application. Refer to Attachment 3, Budget Requirements and Instructions for detailed information.

If an Applicant is selected for a Grant Award under this RFA, only TWC-approved Budget items in Form B, Budget Workbook will be included in the Grant Award.

5.3. Form C, General Terms and Conditions' Exceptions Form

Form C, General Terms and Conditions Exceptions Form will only be used if the Applicant has any specific exceptions to TWC's General Terms and Conditions.

6. Administrative Information and Inquiries

6.1. RFA Schedule of Events

EVENT	DATE and TIME
Posted to TWC Procurement Portal and Electronic State Business Daily (ESBD)	February 26, 2026
Deadline for Submitting Questions or Requests for Clarification	March 6, 2026 at 4:00p.m. Central Time
Estimated Date to Post Answers to Questions or Requests for Clarification	On or after April 1, 2026
Deadline for Submission of Applications Applications must be received by TWC by this deadline if not changed by subsequent Amendment to be considered eligible.	April 10, 2026 by 10:00 a.m. Central Time
Estimated Grant Start Date	July 2026

These dates are a tentative schedule of events. TWC reserves the right to modify these dates at any time upon notice posted to the TWC Procurement Portal. Any dates listed after the Deadline for Submission will occur at the discretion of TWC and may occur earlier or later than scheduled without notification in the TWC Procurement Portal.

TWC reserves the right to amend or withdraw this RFA at any time by posting Amendments or cancellations in the TWC Procurement Portal.

TWC will post the Grant Award decision on the [TWC Procurement Portal](#) after the award(s) are executed. TWC staff will notify unsuccessful Applicants in writing following execution of all Grant Awards. If there are any questions regarding the Grant Award(s), please email [RFA Grants](#) within ten (10) business days of the notice.

No public disclosures or news releases pertaining to the RFA or any resulting grant will be made without the prior written approval of TWC.

6.2. Authorized TWC Contact

All communication about this RFA must be made in writing to the Authorized TWC Contact:

Cassandra Johnson, CTCD, CTCM, Contract Specialist

Email: [RFAGrants](mailto:RFAGrants@twc.texas.gov) (RFAGrants@twc.texas.gov)

6.3. Communications with TWC during the RFA and Award Process

Communication with any TWC personnel in reference to or concerning this RFA, other than the Authorized TWC Contact listed in this RFA, is prohibited. Attempts to ask questions by phone or in person will not be allowed or recognized as valid. This restriction does not preclude discussions between affected parties for the purposes of conducting business unrelated to this Solicitation. Failure to follow this provision may be grounds for disqualification of the Application.

6.4. Question & Answer (Q&A) Document and Requests for Clarification

After the issuance of the RFA, the Q&A Document is a primary source of information for Applicants. Applicants' questions or requests for clarification

must be submitted via the TWC Procurement Portal by the deadline set forth in Section 6.1, RFA Schedule of Events.

Applicants' identifying information will be removed from questions in any responses released. All questions, and requests for clarification must include the following information, including the contact information. Submissions that do not include this information may not be accepted:

- a) RFA Number
- b) Section or paragraph number
- c) Page number of this Solicitation
- d) Section or paragraph number and page number from the attachment or form
- e) Text of passage being questioned
- f) Question
- g) Name of individual submitting question or request for clarification
- h) Organization name
- i) Phone number
- j) Email address

TWC reserves the right to provide a single consolidated response of all similar questions in any manner at TWC's sole discretion.

TWC, at its sole discretion, may respond to questions or other written requests received after the Questions or Requests for Clarifications Deadline for Submission.

TWC will publish the Q&A Document on the TWC Procurement Portal per Section 6.1, RFA Schedule of Events.

TWC reserves the right to amend responses to questions and requests for clarification after posting at any time prior to the deadline for submission of Applications. Amended answers will be posted on the TWC Procurement Portal in a separate, new Amendment. It is Applicant's responsibility to check the TWC Procurement Portal or contact the Authorized TWC Contact for updated responses.

Responses to questions or other written requests for clarification will be posted in one or more Amendments on the TWC Procurement Portal. Responses will not be provided individually to requestors.

6.5. Ambiguity, Conflict, Discrepancy, Clarifications

Applicant must notify the Authorized TWC Contact of any ambiguity, conflict, discrepancy, exclusionary specification, omission, or other error in the RFA in the manner and by the deadline for submitting questions and requests for clarification.

If Applicant fails to properly and timely notify the Authorized TWC Contact of any ambiguity, conflict, discrepancy, exclusionary specification, omission, or other error in the RFA, the Applicant, whether awarded a Grant Award or not will:

- a) have waived any claim of error or ambiguity in the RFA and any resulting Grant Award;
- b) not contest the interpretation by TWC of such provision(s); and
- c) not be entitled to additional reimbursement, relief, or time by reason of any ambiguity, conflict, discrepancy, exclusionary specification, omission, or other error or its later correction.

6.6. Changes, Amendment, or Modification to RFA

TWC reserves the right to change, amend, modify, or cancel this RFA. TWC will post all changes, Amendments and modifications or cancellation on the TWC Procurement Portal.

It is the responsibility of each Applicant to periodically check the TWC Procurement Portal for any additional information regarding this RFA. Failure to check the TWC Procurement Portal will in no way release any Applicant or Grantee from the requirements of posted Amendment or additional information. TWC will not be responsible or liable in any regard for the failure of any individual or entity to receive notification of any posting to the websites or for the failure of any Applicant or Grantee to stay informed of all postings on the TWC Procurement Portal. If the Applicant fails to monitor the TWC Procurement Portal for any changes or modifications to this RFA, such failure will not relieve the Applicant of its obligation to fulfill the requirements as posted.

6.7. Exceptions

Applicants are highly encouraged, in lieu of including exceptions in their Applications, to address all issues that might be advanced by way of exception by submitting questions or requests for clarification pursuant to Section 6.4, Question & Answer (Q&A) Document and Requests for Clarification.

No exception will be considered that is not provided with the Application on Form C, General Terms and Conditions' Exceptions. No exception, nor any other term, condition, or provision in an Application that differs, varies from, or contradicts this RFA, will be considered to be part of any Grant Award resulting from this RFA unless expressly made a part of the Grant Award in writing by TWC.

6.8. Applicant Conference

There will not be an Applicant conference for this RFA.

7. Application Organization and Submission Requirements

7.1. Application Submission Instructions

All Application submissions must be entered into the TWC Procurement Portal. Refer to Section 13, Informational Resources of this Solicitation for the link.

To submit an Application, first-time Applicants must register through the portal. There is no charge. An Applicant can create an account by clicking the “Log in/Register” button on the TWC Procurement Portal page.

For a quick tutorial on how to upload a submission, visit “Creating and Uploading a Submission” page. Refer to Section 13, Informational Resources of this Solicitation for the link.

Applications that are received after the Deadline for Submission will not be accepted nor will additional time be granted to any Applicant.

Any issues with uploading shall first be addressed with Euna Technical Support. Refer to Section 13, Informational Resources of this Solicitation for the link. Contact the Authorized TWC Contact if there are issues with the site prior to the deadline for alternate arrangements if needed. Failure to contact the Authorized TWC Contact prior to the deadline will disqualify any subsequent submittal of an Application.

It is the Applicant's responsibility to ensure its Application is entered into the TWC Procurement Portal before the Deadline for Submission. Applicants should allow for adequate time for submission before the Deadline for Submission.

TWC only accepts Applications submitted in the TWC Procurement Portal. Other methods of submission will not be screened for this RFA.

To protect TWC network(s) and systems, TWC will not accept encrypted documents or access third-party links to download an Application.

TWC will not be responsible for any technical issues that result in late delivery, non-receipt of an Application, inappropriately identified documents, or other submission issue that may lead to disqualification.

All Applications become the property of TWC after submission and receipt and will not be returned to Applicant.

Applicant understands and acknowledges that issuance of this RFA or retention of Applications received in response to this RFA in no way constitutes a commitment to award Grant Award(s) as a result of this RFA.

7.2. Application Format

Applicants responding to this RFA will use TWC's Form A, Core Application; Form B, Budget Workbook; and other forms provided for this RFA. Refer to Submission Checklist of Form A, Core Application for complete list of submission documents.

Failure to use Form A, Core Application; Form B, Budget Workbook; and other forms for this specific RFA (e.g., using a previous form, or component thereof) will result in disqualification prior to evaluation.

Alteration of Form A, Core Application; Form B, Budget Workbook; and other forms (deleting sections, revising formatting, or changing page orientation) may result in disqualification prior to or during evaluation.

Failure to comply with one (1) or more of the following requirements may result in disqualification of the Application:

- a) The Application must be responsive to all requirements in this RFA.
- b) The Application must be in the 8 ½" by 11" paper layout.
- c) The Application must be clearly legible.
- d) The Application must be presented using font type Verdana, or Arial, font size 12 pt., with one (1) inch margins and 1.5 line spacing. The sole 12-point font size exception is for tables, graphs, and appendices, which can be no less than size 10 pt.

Each electronic file should be titled with the RFA number and Applicant's name.

TWC considers the PDF version of the signed Form A, Core Application the only file for evaluation and retention purposes. The Word document will not be reviewed for evaluation and will be used for TWC internal purposes only. Please ensure these two (2) files match.

TWC considers the total requested amount in the Budget Summary Form in Form B, Budget Workbook to be the official requested Budget.

All information conveyed in the submission is subject to validation by TWC. Information obtained by TWC during validation will be considered in the final evaluation and award decision. TWC reserves the right to waive minor technicalities in determining whether to evaluate an Application.

7.3. Modifications of Application

An Applicant may revise its Application by submitting an entirely new submission, complete in all respects, using the method of submission set forth in this RFA. The revision must be received by TWC by the Deadline for Submission of Applications set forth in Section 6.1, RFA Schedule of Events of this Solicitation. Revision requests received after the Deadline for Submission of Applications, set forth in Section 6.1, RFA Schedule of Events of this Solicitation, will not be considered. Additionally, in the event of multiple Applications received, the last version or revised Application received by the Deadline for Submission will replace the Applicant's original and all prior submission(s) in its entirety and the original submission(s) will not be considered.

Unless specifically requested by TWC, material submitted after the Application Deadline for Submission will not be considered.

7.4. Withdrawal of Application

An Application may be withdrawn at any time prior to the execution of a Grant Award by writing to the Authorized TWC Contact. A withdrawn Application will not be considered for award but will be retained by TWC in accordance with the Application Information Confidentiality and Records Retention provisions in this RFA.

7.5. Records Retention

All information submitted in response to this RFA must be retained by TWC for the period specified in [TWC's record retention schedule](https://www.tsl.texas.gov/sites/default/files/public/tslac/slrn/state/schedules/320.pdf) (<https://www.tsl.texas.gov/sites/default/files/public/tslac/slrn/state/schedules/320.pdf>) created pursuant to Texas Government Code, Chapter 441. The information will not be returned to the Applicant.

8. Application Screening and Evaluation

8.1. Overview

A three-step selection process will be used:

- a) Application screening to determine whether the Applicant meets the minimum requirements of this RFA.
- b) Evaluation based upon specific criteria.
- c) Final selection based upon State priorities and other relevant factors, as outlined in Section 9.1, Final Selection of this Solicitation.

8.2. Initial Compliance Screening of Applications

All Applications received by the Deadline for Submission of Applications as outlined in Section 6.1, RFA Schedule of Events of this Solicitation, or subsequent Amendment, will be screened by TWC to determine which Applications meet all the minimum requirements of this RFA and are deemed responsive and qualified for further consideration.

- a) The Application was submitted by an Eligible Applicant, as stated in Section 3, Applicant Eligibility Requirements of this Solicitation.

- b) The Application submitted must include the signature of an authorized representative of the Applicant on the required Certifications of Form A, Core Application.
- c) The Applicant must provide a physical, Texas-based address on the Contact Information Form in the Application that is within the community or communities it proposes to serve.
- d) The Application must include verifiable evidence of its registration by the Texas Secretary of State as a nonprofit or other verifiable documentation, such as Internal Revenue Service Certification (Determination Letter).

At the sole discretion of TWC, Applications with errors, omissions, or compliance issues may be considered non-responsive and may not be considered. The remaining Applications will continue to the evaluation stage and will be considered in the manner and form as which they are received. TWC reserves the right to waive minor informalities in an Application. A minor technicality is an omission or error that, in the determination of TWC if waived or modified, would not give an Applicant an unfair advantage over other Applicants or result in a material change in the Application or RFA requirements. Any disqualifying factor set forth in this RFA does not constitute a technicality.

8.3. TWC Questions or Requests for Clarification for Applications

TWC reserves the right to ask questions or request clarification or revised documents for a submitted Application from any Applicant at any time prior to award. TWC reserves the right to select qualified Applications received in response to this RFA without discussing the Applications with Applicants.

8.4. Evaluation Criteria

Qualified Applications will be evaluated and scored in accordance with the following scoring criteria using Evaluation Criteria of Form A, Core Application.

- a) Executive Summary – Required
- b) Demonstrated Experience – 15 points
- c) Program Plan – 30 points
- d) Program Administration Plan – 25 points
- e) Outcomes and Measures – 15 points
- f) Budget Workbook – 15 points

Relevance and appropriateness of the design and activities to the program and purpose of the Grant program will be considered in the scoring of all evaluation criteria.

8.5. Tied Scores

Tied total scores will be ranked based on highest workplan section score, with the sections considered in the order listed below until the tie is broken.

- a) Program Plan
- b) Program Administration Plan
- c) Outcomes and Measures
- d) Demonstrated Experience
- e) Budget Workbook

In the event two (2) or more Applications are still tied after all sections have been compared, the tie will be broken based on the earliest submission date and time (and includes revisions).

8.6. Grant Application Disclosure

In an effort to maximize state resources and reduce duplication of effort, TWC, at its discretion, may require the Applicant to disclose information regarding the Application for any other award of state, federal, or local grant funding to the Applicant or its Subrecipient(s) within the past two (2) years to provide Workforce Readiness Training. Duplication of program activities may result in disqualification or adjustment of requested Budget.

8.7. Past Performance

TWC reserves the right to request additional information and conduct further inquiries as necessary to evaluate any Application. By submitting an Application, the Applicant generally releases from liability and waives all claims against any party providing information about the Applicant at the request of TWC.

TWC may examine Applicant's past performance which may include, but is not limited to, information about Applicant provided by any governmental entity, whether an agency or political subdivision of the State of Texas, another state, or the Federal government.

Application may be rejected based upon Applicant's prior history with the State of Texas, or with any other party, that demonstrates, without limitation, unsatisfactory performance, adversarial or contentious demeanor, or significant failure(s) to meet contractual or grant obligations.

TWC, at its sole discretion, may also initiate investigations or examinations of Applicant performance based upon media reports. Any negative findings, as determined by TWC in its sole discretion, may result in TWC removing the Applicant from further consideration for award.

Past performance information regarding Applicants may include, but is not limited to

- a) notices of termination;
- b) cure notices;
- c) assessments of liquidated damages;
- d) litigation;
- e) audit reports; and
- f) non-renewals of grants or contracts based on Applicant's unsatisfactory performance.

Applicants also may be rejected as a result of unsatisfactory past performance under any grant(s) or contract(s) as reflected in vendor performance reports, reference checks, or other sources. An Applicant's past performance may be considered prior to making an award determination.

Reasons for which an Applicant may be denied a Grant Award at any point after Application submission include, but are not limited to

- a) Applicant is currently under a corrective action plan through TWC;
- b) Applicant has had repeated, negative performance reports for the same type of deficiency;
- c) Applicant has a record of repeated non-responsiveness to performance issues; or,
- d) any other performance issue that demonstrates that awarding a Grant Award to Applicant would not be in the best interest of the State.

8.8. Compliance for Participation in Grant Awards

In accordance with the reporting requirements established by the Federal Funding Accountability and Transparency Act (FFATA) of 2006, Pub. L. 109-282, as amended by Pub. L. 110-252, title VI, § 6202(a), June 3, 2008, according to the instructions specified in WD Letter 29-12 and subsequent issuances, Eligible Applicants will be required to comply with WD Letter 29-12 and subsequent issuances during the Grant Award.

Before an Applicant submits an Application, it is recommended that the Applicant request a federally assigned UEI through SAM.gov, if it does not already have one. It is also recommended that the Applicant start the process to establish a fully registered SAM.gov account, or, if the Applicant already has a SAM.gov account, ensure that its SAM registration is active and up to date.

A grantee must have a UEI at the time of Grant Award. Grantees that are required to have a SAM.gov account must have a registered account within thirty (30) days after the Grant Award start date.

Information regarding SAM registration may be found in WD Letter 29-12 and subsequent issues, and at SAM.gov. Registering in SAM.gov is free.

Prior to award of a Grant Award as a result of this RFA and in addition to the initial screening of Applications, all required verification checks will be conducted. The information (e.g., legal name and, if applicable, assumed name (dba), tax identification number) provided by Applicant will be used to conduct these checks. At TWC's sole discretion, Applicants found to be barred, prohibited, or otherwise excluded from award of a Grant Award may be disqualified from further consideration under this RFA, pending satisfactory resolution of all compliance issues.

Checks may include the following:

- a) State of Texas Debarment and Warrant Hold. Applicant must not be debarred from doing business with the State of Texas.
- b) State of Texas Divestment Statute Lists. Applicant must not be listed on the Divestment Statute Lists provided by Texas Comptroller of Public Accounts.
- c) System of Award Management (SAM) Exclusions List. Applicant must not be excluded from contract or financial assistance participation at the federal level.

TWC reserves the right to conduct additional checks to determine eligibility to receive a Grant Award.

9. Grant Award Process and Amendments

9.1. Final Selection

After initial screening for eligibility and Application completeness, evaluators will review and score Applications based on the evaluation criteria listed in Evaluation Criteria of Form A, Core Application using only the information provided in the written Application. The final scores will serve as the initial basis for selection of Applications for funding. The panel results are advisory in nature and not binding to TWC. TWC may apply other considerations such as program policy or other selection factors that are essential to the process of selecting Applications that individually or collectively achieve program objectives. In applying these factors, TWC may consult with internal and external subject matter experts.

TWC will make final funding decisions based on Applicant eligibility, evaluation rankings, the funding methodology outlined in Section 4.3, Maximum Award of this Solicitation, and may consider as applicable, geographic distribution across the state, state priorities, reasonableness, availability of funding, cost-effectiveness, and other relevant factors.

9.2. Negotiations

After selecting Applicants for award, TWC may engage in negotiations with selected Applicants. As determined by TWC, the negotiation phase may involve direct contact between the selected Applicant and TWC representative.

Negotiations should not be interpreted as a preliminary intent to award funding unless explicitly stated in writing by TWC and is considered a step to finalize the Application to a state of approval and discuss proposed grant activities. During negotiations, selected Applicants may expect:

- a) an in-depth discussion of the submitted Application and requested Budget; and
- b) requests from TWC for revised documents, clarification, or additional detail regarding the Applicant's submitted Application. These clarifications and additional details, as required, must be submitted in writing by Applicant as finalized during the negotiation.

Should a grant be awarded without discussions, the award will be based on the Applicant's Application submission, which constitutes a binding offer by the Applicant. To receive an award, the Applicant must accept any additional or special terms and conditions listed in the Grant Award and any proposed and accepted changes to the grant Application.

9.3. Uniform Administrative Requirements, Cost Principles, and Audit Requirements for Federal Awards

Executed Grant Awards that TWC finances with federal funds will include an attachment that provides certain federal award information that the UG requires be included in federally funded grants and subgrants.

9.4. Grant Award Amendments

Any Amendment to a grant awarded under this RFA is required to be within the scope of the original Application, resulting grant, and this RFA. A substantial change in the scope of services or Budget through Amendment to the Grant Award will not be allowed.

10. Application Information Confidentiality

Texas Public Information Act – Application Disclosure Requirements

Applications, documentation, and other materials submitted in connection with this RFA or the resulting Grant Award may be subject to public disclosure pursuant to the Texas Public Information Act (PIA), Texas Government Code Chapter 552.

If Applicant asserts that information provided in its Application is exempt from disclosure under the PIA, Applicant must submit two separate, searchable Portable Document Format (PDF) copies (Original Application and “Public Information Act Copy,” including attachments, of the Original Application) as identified below. **These copies are in addition to the original and all copies otherwise required under the provisions of this Solicitation.**

1. Mark Original Application:

- a. Mark the top of the front page with the words "CONTAINS CONFIDENTIAL INFORMATION" in large, bold, capitalized letters (the size of, or equivalent to, 12-point or larger bond font);
 - b. Mark the bottom of each page that contains information that Respondent claims is exempt from public disclosure with the words "CONTAINS CONFIDENTIAL INFORMATION."
 - c. Identify, adjacent to each portion of the Application that Applicant claims is exempt from public disclosure, the claimed exemption from disclosure.
 - d. Ensure there are no redactions in the Original Application.
2. Mark a separate Public Information Act Copy of Application:
 - a. Mark the copy at the top of the front page with "Public Information Act Copy" in large, bold, capitalized letters (the size of, or equivalent to, 12-point font or larger).
 - b. Identify, adjacent to each redaction, the claimed exemption from disclosure. Each identification provided must be identical to those set forth in the Original Application as required in Subsection 1, above. The only difference in required markings and information between the Original Application and the "Public Information Act Copy" of the Application will be redactions – which can only be included in the "Public Information Act Copy."

For more information concerning the Public Information Act, please visit [Office of the Attorney General](https://www.texasattorneygeneral.gov) (<https://www.texasattorneygeneral.gov>).

By submitting an Application under this RFA, Applicant agrees that, if Applicant does not mark the Original Application, provide the required certification in Form A, Core Application, Certifications and submit the Public Information Act Copy, the Application will be considered to be public information that may be released to the public in any manner including, but not limited to, in accordance with the PIA, posted on TWC's public website, and posted on the Legislative Budget Board's public website.

An Application should not be marked or asserted as copyrighted material. If Applicant asserts a copyright to any portion of its Application, by submitting an Application, Applicant agrees to reproduction and posting on public websites by the State of Texas, including TWC and all other state agencies, without cost or liability, and, additionally, agrees to allow the State of Texas to provide a copy of the Application to individuals making a PIA request for the response.

If any or all Applicants submit partial, but not complete, information suggesting inclusion of confidential information and fail to comply with the requirements set forth in this section, TWC, in its sole discretion, reserves the right to (1) disqualify all Applicants that fail to fully comply with the requirements set forth in this section, or (2) to offer all Applicants that fail to fully comply with the requirements set forth in this section additional time to comply.

11. Submission Checklist

Applicant must refer to Submission Checklist of Form A, Core Application for the complete checklist of documents that will be submitted under this RFA. Applicant will complete and submit all required forms. Applicant is responsible for reviewing all RFA requirements and ensuring it submits all documents for a complete Application.

12. List of Attachments

Any Grant Award made will incorporate Attachment 1 and Attachment 2 of this Section 12.

- a) Attachment 1, Workforce Innovation and Opportunities Act Special Terms and Conditions
- b) Attachment 2, General Terms and Conditions
- c) Attachment 3, Budget Requirements and Instructions

13. Informational Resources

13.1. Universal

[Texas Local Workforce Development Boards](https://www.twc.texas.gov/sites/default/files/wf/docs/workforce-board-directory-twc.pdf)

(<https://www.twc.texas.gov/sites/default/files/wf/docs/workforce-board-directory-twc.pdf>)

[Office of Management and Budget's Uniform Guidance \(2 C.F.R. Part 200\)](https://www.ecfr.gov/current/title-2/subtitle-A/chapter-II/part-200?toc=1)

(<https://www.ecfr.gov/current/title-2/subtitle-A/chapter-II/part-200?toc=1>)

[Texas Grant Management Standards \(TxGMS\)](https://comptroller.texas.gov/purchasing/grant-management/)

(<https://comptroller.texas.gov/purchasing/grant-management/>)

[TWC Financial Manual for Grants and Contracts](https://www.twc.texas.gov/agency/grant-administration-financial-reporting)

(<https://www.twc.texas.gov/agency/grant-administration-financial-reporting>)

[WD Letter 29-12 "Federal Funding Accountability and Transparency Act of 2006 – Update"](#) and subsequent issuances

(<https://www.twc.texas.gov/sites/default/files/wf/policy-letter/wd/29-12-twc.pdf>)

[WD Letter 02-18 Change 1 "Handling and Protection of Personally Identifiable Information and Other Sensitive Information"](#) and subsequent issuances

(<https://www.twc.texas.gov/sites/default/files/wf/policy-letter/wd/02-18-ch1-twc.pdf>)

[WD Letter 44-05 "Texas Workforce Commission Online Contract Closeout Process"](#) and subsequent issuances

([twc.texas.gov/sites/default/files/wf/policy-letter/wd/44-05-twc.pdf](https://www.twc.texas.gov/sites/default/files/wf/policy-letter/wd/44-05-twc.pdf))

[WD Letter 04-15, Change 2, "Cash Draw and Expenditure Reporting System Instructions-Update"](#) and subsequent issuances

([twc.texas.gov/sites/default/files/wf/policy-letter/wd/04-15-ch2-twc.pdf](https://www.twc.texas.gov/sites/default/files/wf/policy-letter/wd/04-15-ch2-twc.pdf))

[WD Letter 04-15, Attachment 1, Cost Category Matrices](#)

([twc.texas.gov/sites/default/files/wf/policy-letter/wd/04-15-ch2-att1-twc.xlsx](https://www.twc.texas.gov/sites/default/files/wf/policy-letter/wd/04-15-ch2-att1-twc.xlsx))

[WD Letter 04-15, Attachment 2, Cost Category Descriptions](#)

([twc.texas.gov/sites/default/files/wf/policy-letter/wd/04-15-ch2-att2-twc.pdf](https://www.twc.texas.gov/sites/default/files/wf/policy-letter/wd/04-15-ch2-att2-twc.pdf))

[WD Letter 04-15, Attachment 3, Summary of Charges](#)

([twc.texas.gov/sites/default/files/wf/policy-letter/wd/04-15-ch2-att3-twc.pdf](https://www.twc.texas.gov/sites/default/files/wf/policy-letter/wd/04-15-ch2-att3-twc.pdf))

[State of Texas Debarred Vendor List](#)

(<https://comptroller.texas.gov/purchasing/programs/vendor-performance-tracking/debarred-vendors.php>)

[State of Texas Divestment Statute Lists](#)

(<https://comptroller.texas.gov/purchasing/publications/divestment.php>)

[System for Award Management \(SAM.gov\)](#)

(<https://sam.gov/content/home>)

[Electronic State Business Daily Search](#)

(<https://www.txsmartbuy.gov/esbd>)

[TWC Procurement Portal](#)

(<https://twc-texas-gov.bonfirehub.com/portal/?tab=openOpportunities>)

[Euna Technical Support](#)

(<https://twc-texas-gov.bonfirehub.com/portal/support>)

[Creating and Uploading a Submission](#)

(<https://customer.eunasolutions.com/public/s/article/creating-and-uploading-a-submission>)

13.2. Program Specific

[Texas Essential Knowledge and Skills](#)

(<https://tea.texas.gov/academics/curriculum-standards/teks-review/texas-essential-knowledge-and-skills>)